

COMP2300 Transcripts 25/26: Sexual Health Services

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The following eight transcripts record interviews with participants who have engaged with sexual health services. They have been purposively sampled to include a diverse range of users with different backgrounds and needs.

Gender:

Man

Age:

22

Location:

Manchester

Interviewer Good morning. Please could you tell me a little bit about how you have used sexual health services in the past?

Participant Morning. OK. I've used sexual health services a few times over the past couple of years. Mostly, I go when I notice something that worries me, like if I have symptoms that I'm not sure about. I don't go regularly or anything like that—it's more of a "when I need to" kind of thing. The first time I went was when I had some irritation and I was a bit panicked, to be honest. I didn't really know what to expect, but I booked an appointment at a clinic near where I live in Manchester. Since then, I've been a couple more times, usually when I felt like something wasn't quite right. I know you can go for regular check-ups, but I've only gone when there's been a specific reason, like symptoms or when I've been in a new relationship and wanted to be sure everything was okay.

Interviewer Was the potential of more regular check-ups discussed with you when you visited?

Participant Yeah, I think it was mentioned, but it wasn't like a big part of the conversation. I remember one of the nurses saying something about how regular check-ups can be a good idea, especially if you're sexually active with more than one partner. They gave me some leaflets about it too. But I guess because I usually only go when I have symptoms, it wasn't really pushed or anything. Maybe they assumed I wasn't that interested, or they didn't want to make me feel uncomfortable by suggesting I come more often. I've thought about it a few times, but I just haven't made it a habit yet.

Interviewer Did you read those leaflets?

Participant I think I gave them a quick look then probably binned them in case anyone else saw. Don't want to read a leaflet about that on the bus you know. I think some of it was quite generic. Stuff I'd heard before. Wear a condom, get tested, that stuff.

Interviewer That thought about the bus seems interesting, do you feel like there's some stigma around accessing sexual health services?

Participant Definitely, you worry that people might find out and what they'll think, and it can make you worried to seek help. Maybe there's a sense of embarrassment or shame associated with going to a clinic. Some people might feel that if they're going to a sexual health service, it means they've done something wrong. Like me, I felt that nervousness the first time I went in. Even though I know that sexual health issues are common right and that everyone should take care of their health, it still seems awkward to talk about it and there might be judgment from family or friends, which I'd be a bit worried about.

Interviewer And were you reminded about the possibility of going for a check-up; would a reminder have helped, do you think?

Participant No, I don't think I ever got a reminder. Like, after my visits, they didn't follow up or send any messages suggesting I come back for a regular check-up or anything like that. To be honest, a reminder probably would've helped. It's not that I don't care about my health, but life happens and it's easy to forget or just put it off. If I got a text or something saying, "it's been a few months since your last check-up, why not book an appointment?" I'd probably take it more seriously. It would make it

easier to remember, and it would feel more normal to just go in regularly. I think it's one of those things where, unless something feels wrong, you don't really think about it. So, a reminder might be useful.

Interviewer Do you recall getting reminders about other services - perhaps dentist, or optician - reminding you to book routine appointments? Do you find those useful?

Participant Yeah, I definitely get reminders for other things, like the dentist and the optician. My dentist always sends me a text or an email every six months saying it's time to book a check-up, and my optician does the same thing once a year. I think it's pretty useful, actually. I mean, I probably wouldn't remember to book those appointments on my own. It's not that I don't think they're important, but like I said, life gets busy, and if no one reminds me, it's easy to just forget. When I get the message, it feels like a little prompt to take care of myself, so I just book it and get it over with. I think if sexual health did the same, like sending a reminder every so often, it would have the same effect. It would make it feel more routine, like going to the dentist, instead of something you only do when you're worried about something being wrong.

Interviewer I'd like to think more about the reasons you attended the service, and the value it provided. You mentioned getting checked and feeling reassured. It sounds like testing and possibly treatment were your main motivations for attending?

Participant Yeah, that's it. My reason for going has always been to get checked out when I'm worried about something. I don't go to get a general check-up; it's usually when I have symptoms or if I've had a new partner and I want to make sure everything's okay. So, testing and maybe getting treatment if I need it are definitely the main things. The first time I went, I was really anxious because I had some irritation, and I was worried it could be something serious. It was a bit awkward, but the staff were really good about it—they explained everything, did the tests, and I got my results pretty quick. It wasn't anything serious, but it was reassuring to know. The same thing happened other times. I had a bit of a scare once when I noticed some unusual symptoms, and I just wanted to get tested and find out what was going on. Even when it turned out to be nothing serious, it gave me some peace of mind, which is worth it. So yeah, I'd say the main value is definitely the reassurance, knowing I can get tested and get answers if I'm worried.

Interviewer Do services like advice or access to free contraception appeal to you? It sounds like they were not your main reason for visiting.

Participant Yeah, those services are useful, but they weren't really my main reason for visiting you know. The focus was more on getting tested because of specific concerns at the time. I remember seeing posters and leaflets about things like free condoms, different types of contraception, and advice on sexual health, but I didn't really go in thinking about that. Although I did pick up some free condoms a couple of times when I was there, because that's cheaper isn't it. It's convenient, and you don't feel awkward about asking for them because they're just there for anyone to take. I think having access to that kind of stuff is important, and maybe if I'd gone in for general check-ups more often, I would've used advice or something. It's good that it's all there in one place, even if I didn't make the most of it.

Interviewer How did you find engaging with the service? Was it easy to get an appointment?

Participant Overall, I'd say it was pretty straightforward, but there were a few times when it felt a bit tricky. The first time I went, I was a bit nervous about the whole thing, but booking the appointment wasn't too hard. I just looked up clinics in Manchester online and called one near me. They had some walk-in slots, but I decided to book ahead because I didn't want to wait around. I remember there being a bit of a wait for an appointment, maybe a week or so, which felt like a long time when you're

anxious about symptoms. But once I got there, it was easy enough. The staff were friendly, and they made me feel comfortable even though I was a bit embarrassed to talk about what was going on. On other occasions, I've used online booking, which was quicker. That's definitely made things easier because you can see the available slots and choose a time that suits you without having to call. I think it would be even better if more clinics had that option. So, I'd say it wasn't too difficult, but there were moments when I wished it was quicker, especially when you're worried and just want to get it sorted. If they could reduce waiting times a bit or make it easier to book last-minute appointments, that would be a big help.

Interviewer You mentioned nervousness, but also that the staff were friendly. Did you feel welcomed at the service, and like it was aimed you?

Participant Yeah, I did feel welcomed, which was a relief. I was pretty nervous the first time I went—because I didn't know what to expect, and partly I felt a bit embarrassed about having to talk about my symptoms. But the staff were friendly, and they didn't make me feel judged or anything. They were calm, professional, and just easy to talk to. That made me relax a bit. As for whether it felt like it was aimed at people like me, I'd say yes and no. I mean, the clinic itself felt quite neutral and welcoming, like anyone could walk in, which is good. But I didn't really see much that made me feel like it was specifically for people my age or from my background. There were posters and leaflets about general sexual health, contraception, and different infections, but they didn't really have anything that felt specific to young men, or people from the Asian community, for example. I didn't feel out of place or anything, but maybe it would've been nice to see something that acknowledged people from different backgrounds or had info more tailored to young men. Like, if there were posters or resources that felt more relevant, it might've made me feel a bit more connected or maybe I could've learned something useful. I don't know what. But, I'd say the staff made me pretty welcome.

Interviewer And may I ask if you've ever needed treatment?

Participant Yeah, I did need treatment once. It was a while ago, during one of the times I went in because I was having some symptoms that were worrying me. After they did the tests, it turned out I had an infection that needed treating. The staff were really clear about it. They explained what it was, how it could have happened, and what the treatment would involve. I was well embarrassed, but they handled it. Like, it was no big deal and just a normal thing they deal with every day, which made me feel better. They gave me some antibiotic pills and explained how to take them properly, and they also made sure I understood what I needed to do to avoid passing the infection to anyone else. I was worried it might be complicated, but it was pretty straightforward, and they were open to answering any questions I had. I appreciated how quick it was. I got my results and the treatment on the same day, so I didn't have to keep stressing about it. It wasn't a fun experience, obviously, but they made it as easy as possible.

Interviewer And were you asked to return for follow-up testing? Did you attend that appointment?

Participant Yeah, I was asked to come back for a follow-up, they said they need to check if the treatment works. They wanted to make sure that the infection is completely gone. I think they scheduled it for like a month after I finished the pills. I was a bit hesitant at first. I had already gone through the stress of getting tested and then dealing with the treatment, so I wasn't really happy to go back again. But I understood it was important to make sure, so I did go. That was a lot less nerve-racking than the first visit. I knew where to go, and the staff, it felt a bit more comfortable. They did the tests and everything came back clear, and I was relieved about it. I'm glad I went back it really put my mind at ease that I was in the clear and didn't have to worry about it.

Interviewer And during that process, did you feel like you had adequate advice and information about the infection and the treatment?

Participant Yeah I got adequate advice and information. When I first went in and they diagnosed the infection, the staff took some time to explain everything clearly. They talked me through what the infection was, how it might have happened, and what I needed to know about treatment. They gave me some written information, too. That was helpful because I could take it home and read it again later. They encouraged me to ask questions and made it clear that I could call up if I had any concerns after I left the clinic. During the follow-up appointment, they also checked in to see how I was doing and if I had any questions about the treatment or any side effects I might have experienced. It felt reassuring to know they were there to support me through it. Overall, I think they did a great job of providing the right information and making sure I felt informed and confident about what was going on. It made the whole experience a lot less stressful for me.

Interviewer That's great. It sounds like your experience was mostly positive. Did anything about your experience feel like it was less positive, or could have been improved?

Participant Yeah, while my experience was mostly positive, there were definitely a few areas where things could have been better. One thing that stood out was the wait time for an appointment. The first time I went, I had to wait about a week, and when you're anxious about symptoms, that feels like a long time. It would be great if there were more options for same-day or next-day appointments, especially for people who are worried about something. Another thing was the information about prevention and regular check-ups. While I got good advice when I needed treatment, I think it would have been helpful to have more discussions about how to stay healthy in general—like information on testing, safe sex, and where to find resources that are relevant. And I think the waiting area could be made a bit more comfortable. It's not very inviting. A more relaxed environment might reduce some of the anxiety people feel when they're waiting.

Interviewer Did you need to share your positive test result with any previous sexual partners? Did you manage to do so, and how did it go?

Participant Yes, I did need to share my positive test result with a previous sexual partner. I knew it was important to let her know so she could get tested and take care of their own health. It was definitely a bit awkward for me to bring it up, but I knew it was the right thing to do. I reached out to her through a message, just to keep it less confrontational. I explained that I had been tested and found out I had an infection, and that it would be good for her to get checked as well. I tried to keep it straightforward and not make it too heavy. She was chill about it and thanked me for letting her know, and said she'd get tested. It felt like a relief to have the conversation, even though I was nervous.

Interviewer Is there anything else you thought was good or bad about your use of the sexual health service?

Participant No, I think that covers it. Some of it was good, some things need to be improved. Make it easier to get an appointment, make the information more relevant. Not sure how they can make it less embarrassing, but they should do that.

Interviewer Thanks very much for your time.

Participant Anytime. Hope it goes well.

Gender:

Man

Age:

19

Location:

Portsmouth

Interviewer Thank you for agreeing to speak with me today. To start off, have you ever looked for sexual health advice or information? If so, what sources did you find, and which were useful?

Participant Yes, I've definitely looked for information before. I'd start with online resources, often websites aimed at gay men's health because I think it's more relevant. There's a website called "Terrence Higgins Trust" that has a lot of information specifically for gay men, but it can be challenging to access due to my eyesight. I can't read small text, so I rely on screen magnifiers or high-contrast options, which not every website has. Sometimes I have to trade off information that's really relevant against information that I can read easily enough. It depends, though; if I'm tired after a long day then accessing information is harder, but if I'm relaxed and rested maybe I can work through something less accessible.

Interviewer That sounds frustrating. Did you find any specific websites or resources that were particularly accommodating for your needs?

Participant Forums were quite useful. Often they have buttons for larger text and better contrast built in. One forum had discussions about personal experiences with PrEP, and reading those threads helped me understand it better. I appreciated how real people shared their challenges and successes, which let me know what to expect. But I often had to read through a lot of posts to find the specific information I needed, so it's not always very efficient. The posts often explained how the service really works, though. Like what you need to say to a doctor to get access to PrEP. The NHS website is vaguer about that. I guess they want the doctors to be in charge of what you get, but once I had been reading about PrEP I really felt like it was a good thing to do so I wanted to make sure I could get it.

Interviewer It sounds like online forums provided some support but also had challenges. Have you engaged with sexual health services directly in the past?

Participant Yes, I've been to my local sexual health clinic several times. I first went in to inquire about PrEP, but they told me that regular STI testing like every three months was a requirement to get it.

Interviewer What services were you looking for when you went there?

Participant Mainly, I was looking for PrEP, but I also wanted to get tested for STIs. I knew it was important, being sexually active, and I wanted to make sure I was being responsible of my health, and also being respectful of partners.

Interviewer What motivated you to engage with those services specifically?

Participant My main motivation was to stay safe and responsible. I read how effective PrEP can be, like really reducing HIV, and I really wanted to take control of my sexual health. Knowing I could reduce the risk of HIV and not worry was important, because the other STIs aren't so serious and can be cured.

Interviewer Can you tell me about your experience trying to get an appointment? What was that process like for you?

Participant Trying to book an appointment was annoying. I tried to book online, but their website isn't very accessible. The text was too small and didn't have the contrast I need, so I ended up calling them just because it seemed like it would be easier. When I finally reached someone, they informed me that I had to wait about two weeks for an appointment. I felt a bit annoyed that it would take so long, but I had read about similar things in the forums so it wasn't a big surprise.

Interviewer That sounds frustrating. How did you feel accessing the service once you got there? Was it comfortable?

Participant Once I arrived, it was a mixed experience. The staff were friendly and were using words that seemed normal, instead of really medical, which made it easier to understand what they meant. But the waiting area felt very clinical and not very comfortable. I could hear other people's conversations about their health, and it felt a bit invasive. I think they could protect people's privacy better. I recognised one person, just an acquaintance, but I was worried people might recognise me and wonder why I was there. I tried to look calm and not anxious, so if someone saw me they would know it was just routine and not think I had an STI or something. Oh and at reception they asked me to fill in a paper form, with quite small text that was quite difficult for me to read. I had to say I was having a problem to read some of it, but they said I could take it into the consultation and the nurse there helped me to complete it.

Interviewer Were you offered any other services while you were there?

Participant Yes, they definitely encouraged me to get tested for STIs, which I appreciated. I knew it was mandatory for getting PrEP, but I was glad they took the time to explain why it's so important. They also mentioned other services like counseling and sexual health workshops, but I wasn't interested in those at the time. I feel like I've been told about condoms loads of times, what else is there to know?

Interviewer Do you have a regular schedule for engaging with sexual health services, or is it more ad-hoc?

Participant My visits are pretty ad-hoc. I tend to go in whenever I feel the need to get tested or if I'm running out of PrEP. I wish I could establish a more regular routine, but it's hard to keep track. It often depends on my schedule and whether I feel comfortable or if I have concerns.

Interviewer You mentioned being quite ad-hoc, but also that you sometimes need to refill your PrEP supply. Tell me about how that works.

Participant I take PrEP on demand, so it varies how long the supply lasts. When it starts to get low, I need to make another appointment for a refill.

Interviewer And how do you find getting refills?

Participant It's easy enough. You need to plan ahead, though. It can sometimes be a fortnight before you can get an appointment, so I know that when I'm down to less than half a bottle it could be urgent. Sometimes that 15 pills will last a month or so, but if I'm taking one a day that's only a fortnight supply. In general I probably take more PrEP than I need, because on demand starts with a two-pill dose, followed by a single daily pill. I think sometimes I could just take a single first dose but I don't really understand the rules and I think it's better to take too much than too little.

Interviewer That's interesting, when would it be OK to take a single dose?

Participant I think if it's less than a week since the last dose or something, technically you can just take one pill to start the protection as long as you follow up. Sometimes I can't remember how long it's

been, or I worry that I've misremembered the rules. I know if I take two pills, wait 2 hours, then I'm protected, and just need to take the two single doses the days following.

Interviewer And do you take those follow doses reliable?

Participant Yes, I think fairly reliably. There are one or two times I have forgotten to take them on time but remembered a few hours later. I think that is OK, but it does worry me a bit that I might completely forget one day and not be protected. Setting an alarm on my phone helps; but you have to remember to do that in advance.

Interviewer That's interesting, thanks for sharing. Have you ever needed treatment for an STI?

Participant Yes, I tested positive for chlamydia once. It was fine, they gave me some antibiotics and then a week or so later it was gone.

Interviewer Can you walk me through that process? What was it like for you?

Participant The initial test was a bit of a surprise. I hadn't experienced it before. When they called me with the results, I felt a bit of a shock. When I went in for treatment, I remember sitting in the clinic room, feeling a mix of panic and embarrassment. Like, I was worried about people thinking I was there for treatment the first time I went! They reassured me that chlamydia is easily treatable, which calmed me down a bit. The doctor explained the treatment process, just a couple of tablets a day for a few days.

Interviewer How did you feel at different points during that process?

Participant Once I got over the initial shock, it was mostly fine. Sitting in the waiting room I felt quite anxious and self-conscious, but once I saw the doctor they were really good and I felt much calmer.

Interviewer Do you think you had adequate information and advice at each stage of that process?

Participant I think so, yes, but I think I could have benefited from more visual aids, like diagrams or charts. Sometimes I felt they assumed I understood everything because I was young, but there were still gaps in my knowledge. I didn't know I should go back for a follow test after the antibiotics, until they explained why. I assumed they just always worked and I could just carry on.

Interviewer Did you need to notify anyone about your positive result? If so, what was that experience like?

Participant Yes, I had to tell my last partner, which was really awkward. I drafted the message several times, worried about how he'd react. But I just sent a straightforward message, and he was very understanding. We discussed it, and he got tested, and didn't make a fuss about it. I guess this stuff happens. I think now I've seen it from that side, I would be the same if someone told me.

Interviewer In general, what do you think has been positive about your engagements with sexual health services?

Participant I think the positive aspect has been the support from the staff. They've been mostly understanding and knowledgeable, which I really appreciate. Having access to PrEP and knowing I have options has empowered me to take charge of my sexual health.

Interviewer And what, if anything, has been negative or left room for improvement?

Participant Definitely the accessibility issues. The clinic could do more to ensure their online and physical resources are friendly for people with disabilities. The website navigation is a pain, and I think they could benefit from clearer forms and information when you visit.

Interviewer Thank you for sharing all of this with me.

Participant No problem! I hope it helps.

Gender:

Non-binary

Age:

20

Location:

Nottingham / Slough

Interviewer Thank you for taking the time to speak to me today. To start off, have you ever looked for sexual health advice or information? If so, what sources did you find, and which were useful?

Participant Yeah, I definitely have. When I first started looking into sexual health, I started with Google. I wanted to find out the options available to me, especially regarding PrEP and STI testing. I found the NHS website to be a bit dry but useful for the basics. But I found more relatable content on social media. There are some accounts on Instagram that provide infographics and personal stories that seemed relevant to me. They made sexual health feel less clinical, and more like part of a healthy sex life. I'm also part of some forums on Reddit and I noticed that people share their sexual health experiences, and that's valuable too. It's good to see that other people have questions, and read what advice they get from others.

Interviewer That's interesting! So it sounds like online resources are your preference. Are there any specific forums or social media accounts you found particularly useful?

Participant Absolutely! There's this one account on Instagram that focuses specifically on non-binary health; they do a lot of myth-busting and answer common questions in a straightforward way. I also like Reddit threads where people discuss their experiences with clinics and share tips on how to access services. It's helpful to see what others have gone through. I remember that I saw a thread in the Nottingham reddit about sexual health services when I first started searching, and that was a helpful first step. Since I moved to study in Slough, I had to adjust to the service available here and so I went straight to Reddit to see what people were saying about the local ones.

Interviewer Great. And have you engaged with sexual health services in the past?

Participant Yes, I have, not always consistently though. I've gone to the clinic for testing a few times and once for a discussion about PrEP.

Interviewer What services were you looking for during those visits?

Participant Mostly testing and information about PrEP. I wanted to make sure I was being responsible about my health. To be honest I'm quite sexually active since I moved here, and so I became a bit more conscious about it. Back home I had been, but only if for some reason I was worried about something. But it's also been tough because I've experienced interruptions in my access to care whenever I move between Nottingham and Slough. So over the summer for instance, I was back home and probably missed what should have been a routine appointment. There are times I've thought I should be getting more regular check-ups, but then I run into all those logistical issues and they make it harder than I think it should be.

Interviewer What initially motivated you to seek those services out?

Participant Honestly, it was initially that I lost my virginity and all the school sex education came back to me and I was like oh my god what if I've got an STI now? So I guess I was aware of the risks and perhaps wanted to reassure myself. I think now it's more about being responsible and taking care of myself; fear isn't the big motivator now; I guess I've calmed down in that way. At university, conversations and campaigns around sexual health are quite common, which probably encouraged

me to be more proactive. But the reality is that moving back and forth complicates things. I often wonder if I should wait until I'm back in Nottingham or vice versa to get tested, but then what if I have to wait a few weeks for an appointment? And if I did need treatment, but found out a week later, would I need to go all the way back? There's too much to think about.

Interviewer I can see that. What was your experience like trying to get an appointment? What was the process?

Participant Trying to get an appointment is honestly one of the most frustrating parts. In Nottingham, I got to know the service, but in Slough, I was starting from scratch. I've called the phone number and been put on hold for ages or been told they're fully booked for weeks. Sometimes it feels like gambling; will they have appointments today or am I just wasting an hour of my life? When I finally do get an appointment, I often have to think about whether I can arrange to be there at the right time, especially if they offer something at a location I haven't been to before or which is further away. So not good, I guess. Really frustrating.

Interviewer That does sound very frustrating. How did you feel when you were able to access those services?

Participant It's been mixed. When I finally manage to get an appointment, I usually feel relieved but also generally a bit anxious. I know I said I'm not really motivated by the fear any more, but clinics are a bit unsettling. I don't really like going there. The staff are generally friendly, but the atmosphere can feel clinical, which doesn't help when you're already nervous. And since I don't fit neatly into their categories of male or female, it sometimes feels awkward when they ask me to choose which side of the clinic I need. I wish there was an option for people like me, or even that they'd work it out beforehand and not have to ask each time, but that's not something I've seen in the services I've accessed.

Interviewer That's a very valid point. You mentioned feeling like the split of services didn't reflect your identity. Can you elaborate on that a bit?

Participant Sure. When I walk into a clinic, and they ask me if I'm there for the male or female service, it makes me feel like I have to justify my presence. I don't feel like I fit well into either category, and I think there should be more inclusivity. Or even some guidance. It's a health service, so maybe physically they need to know my sex assigned at birth, but sex is also quite social, so should it be based more on risk? Medically I don't really know. And can't the doctors deal with both, anyway? It's not just about gender; it's about how I feel in those spaces. Being asked to pick a side kind of takes away from the support I need when I'm there for care. I don't pick a side in most of my life, so it feels a bit retrograde. I end up feeling more anxious, which is the opposite of what I want.

Interviewer I can imagine that would be uncomfortable. Were you offered other services at the same time during your visits?

Participant Sometimes, yes. When I went for the PrEP discussion, they brought up various vaccinations as well. I think they're trying to be comprehensive, but it can feel overwhelming, especially if I'm not ready to address everything at once. It's a lot to digest, especially when I'm trying to balance everything else in my life. I wasn't really expecting it; so some more information about what to expect during the consultation might have made me feel calmer.

Interviewer Do you have a regular schedule for engaging with sexual health services, or is it more ad-hoc?

Participant It's pretty ad-hoc. Like I said, I've been getting a bit more regular but I think I should be more consistent, but with my schedule at uni and my travels back home, it's hard to establish a routine. I often think, "Okay, I'll go get tested next time I'm back in Nottingham," but that can easily slip my mind if I'm busy catching up with people. The lack of continuity makes it challenging to stay on top of follow-up appointments, especially for things like repeat STI testing or managing PrEP. And I don't know if the clinic at home would even refill my prescription if I needed them to, because I guess they don't have my history and they'd need to ask me everything again. I expect if they did ask, I wouldn't be able to tell them exactly which vaccinations I'd had and when, too.

Interviewer That's understandable. Do you try to track when you might be due to get tested?

Participant Not actively. Sometimes I think 'oh it's time I went to checked' and sometimes I try to work out how long ago my last results came. Usually they come in as text messages, so I have to scroll through my old messages to find the last messages with results in it. That way I can generally work it out, if I need to. Although I guess it's not the most convenient process!

Interviewer Oh that's a good way to find out, thanks for sharing it. Could I ask if you have you ever needed treatment for an STI?

Participant Yes, I actually did once. I tested positive for chlamydia about six months ago.

Interviewer I'm sorry to hear that. What was that process like for you?

Participant It was definitely nerve-wracking. I remember feeling a mix of anxiety and embarrassment when I got the text. They followed up later the same day with a phone call and the nurse who spoke to me was really kind, which helped calm my nerves a bit. I think I felt some stigma, like I'd been caught doing something wrong. They explained the treatment process and what to expect, but I felt like I needed more time to ask questions. When you're in that situation, you're just trying to absorb everything, and it's hard to focus.

Interviewer And at different points in that treatment process, how did you feel?

Participant Initially, I felt a bit scared and embarrassed, but when the nurse reassured me that it was a common issue and treatable, I felt a bit of relief. It's just a course of antibiotics for a week, then a follow-up test. But after the first appointment, I started worrying about how to tell my partners. Those conversations were incredibly stressful, but I was lucky that they were understanding. The follow up test was fine, I was looking forward to it being sorted out, and it felt like the final step in it all being over.

Interviewer How did you tell your partners?

Participant A couple of people I messaged on WhatsApp. One person, who I'm closer to, I told in person - just because we were meeting up anyway. One person who I'd met through an app was a bit harder, I had to scroll back through my messages to find him and let him know. He read the message but didn't reply. I guess he didn't block me either, though. Seemed a bit weird not to say anything, but we'd only met once so perhaps he didn't know what to say. I hope he went to get tested.

Interviewer Did you feel you had adequate information and advice at each stage of treatment, or was there anything more you wished you had?

Participant I think I could've benefited from more follow-up resources. The nurse gave me leaflets when I went for treatment, but I guess by that point I'd already been worrying about it for a couple of

days, since the positive result. I would've liked to have some reassurance and things to read immediately.

Interviewer You mentioned telling partners, what was that experience like?

Participant Yes, I had to inform a couple of my partners, and that was really nerve-wracking. I was so nervous about how they'd react, and it was emotionally taxing. Thankfully, they were understanding and supportive, but I can imagine it could have gone very differently. They did offer to notify partners for me, but it felt even weirder handing over details like that. Like it wasn't my business to be telling a nurse people's phone numbers. Like an invasion of their privacy.

Interviewer It's good to hear that it went smoothly, but I can imagine it was still difficult. In general, what do you think has been positive about your engagements with sexual health services?

Participant I genuinely appreciate that the services are there and that help is theoretically accessible when I need it. The staff, for the most part, have been supportive, which is crucial. Having people who understand that this can be a sensitive topic and that I might be anxious has been nice.

Interviewer And what, if anything, has been negative or left room for improvement?

Participant I think the biggest issue is the lack of inclusivity and understanding for non-binary identities, and the general difficult accessing appointments. There needs to be more awareness and training for staff about non-binary issues, and better ways to understand how I fit into the service or to communicate that information. It's really disheartening when you want to be proactive about your health but feel like the system is pushing back against you. And it's frustrating to keep having to navigate the different clinics at home and at uni.

Interviewer Thank you for sharing your thoughts and experiences today. Your insights are so valuable, and I appreciate your openness.

Participant No problem! I'm glad to share. I hope the services can be improved, and I think by sharing they might hear about what the problems are.

Gender:

Woman

Age:

25

Location:

Brighton

Interviewer Thanks for taking the time to chat with me today. To start off, have you ever looked for sexual health advice or information? If so, what sources did you find, and which ones were useful?

Participant Yeah, I have. I guess like most people, I started by looking online. When I was first transitioning, I wanted to make sure I was informed about everything, including how hormones might affect my sexual health. I found a few websites like NHS and Terrence Higgins Trust quite helpful, especially when it came to general advice on things like STIs and PrEP. But I've ended up relying more on LGBTQ+ community forums and local groups here in Brighton, there's informal knowledge about how to actually navigate the services that I've found useful, and often the experiences other people have are really useful to hear about. There's a group called "Trans Pride Brighton" that has a really supportive community, and sometimes people share their own experiences, which feels more relatable than just reading a medical page.

Interviewer It sounds like you've found a mix of formal and community-based resources. Have you engaged with sexual health services in the past?

Participant Yeah, I've used a few different services over the last few years. I've been for regular STI testing, I often use the postal testing kits, and I'm on PrEP now. And, once, I went to talk about contraception because I was a bit confused about how my hormones would affect that, but it was more for peace of mind.

Interviewer What were your motivations for engaging with those services?

Participant Mostly just to be proactive. When I started transitioning, I realized there was still a lot I didn't know about how hormones could affect things like my risk for STIs or if there was any extra precautions I should take. I wanted to make sure I was protecting myself and my partners. Being on PrEP gives me peace of mind, especially since I'm in a more open relationship right now. Initially I felt like there was some stigma around PrEP but it feels like a lot of people are using it now and I think it's seen as the responsible thing to do, at least among my queer friend group.

Interviewer Can you tell me what it was like trying to get an appointment for these services? How did the process go?

Participant It varied. For the most part, getting an appointment for STI testing has been okay; I can usually book online, and there are a few clinics in Brighton that are quite easy to get to. Online booking isn't the clearest process; and it took me a while to work it out the first time! It sometimes takes a few attempts because appointments run out; sometimes you need to try at the right time of day. Accessing PrEP was more difficult; I couldn't find the service I needed in the online booking service and had to phone up and request a callback, then once I had an appointment I had to have a pretty long chat with a nurse who didn't seem completely sure about the protocol for trans women, which made me feel a bit awkward. I felt I had to prove that I needed it. The process for PrEP involves regular blood and kidney tests, and screening, and remembering to do that and then book the appointments, or when my last test was, is a bit more difficult.

Interviewer Can you elaborate on that? What made it difficult?

Participant Well I'm not great at keeping track of appointments. I try, but sometimes I forget when my follow-ups are, or whether I'm still waiting for results, and whether I'm due for an in-person visit instead of just the postal kit. I wish they had a system where they sent reminders a couple of weeks in advance or something, or maybe even let you choose how often you get reminders. That would be really helpful. Actually, I don't really know why they aren't more proactive at helping me to manage my care. It feels like all the onus is on me, but the protocols seem to change and so I don't always know what I should be asking for, and whether I should be asking for appointments. Come to think of it, vaccinations are even worse; some vaccinations need to be done once, others need several boosters at different intervals. I've probably had more injections than I need to, just because of forgetting to get boosters in time.

Interviewer I can see how that would make things tricky. When you managed to attend in person, how did you find the experience of accessing those services? Were there aspects that felt particularly comfortable or uncomfortable?

Participant It's been a mix. Brighton is pretty queer-friendly, so that helps. The staff at the clinics I've been to are usually respectful and try to be understanding, but there have been a few times where I felt like I was getting extra questions because I'm trans. Like, I'd mention that I'm on hormones, and the tone of the conversation would shift, and they'd start asking things that didn't seem necessary. I get that they might just want to be thorough, but it sometimes feels like I have to explain myself more than a cis person would.

Interviewer Were you ever offered other services at the same time, like advice on contraception or other forms of testing?

Participant Yeah, sometimes. When I first started PrEP, they did ask if I wanted to do a full sexual health screening, which was great. I felt like I was being looked after. But other times, especially when I was just coming in for an STI test, they didn't really offer anything else. I think it depends on who you see. There's also been times I wish I could sync up my PrEP and hormone check-ups so I could get everything done in one visit to the hospital and maybe get all the blood samples taken at once, but that hasn't happened.

Interviewer Do you have a regular schedule for engaging with sexual health services, or is it more on an ad-hoc basis?

Participant I try to keep it regular, but it ends up being a bit ad-hoc because of the reminder issue. Ideally, I'd get tested every three months in person or using the postal kits and keep up with my PrEP appointments, but sometimes I lose track of when I'm due for each one. I'm definitely more consistent when I get reminders—like, if the clinic sent a reminder at the start of the month for an appointment at the end, like my dentist does, I'd be much more likely to remember it.

Interviewer Have you ever needed treatment for an STI?

Participant No, thankfully. I've been lucky so far, but I know it can happen to anyone, so that's part of why I stay on top of testing and use PrEP.

Interviewer In general, what do you think has been positive about your engagements with sexual health services?

Participant I'd say the best thing is that the clinics I've been to in Brighton are generally pretty welcoming. I don't think I've ever felt outright discriminated against, which I know isn't the case everywhere. The staff usually try their best to be respectful, and there's a sense of understanding

around trans issues. Plus, being able to get PrEP has been a huge positive for me—it's something that gives me peace of mind, and I'm really grateful it's available.

Interviewer And what, if anything, has been negative or left room for improvement?

Participant I think there's a few things. Like I mentioned, I'd really like it if the reminder system was better. It would also be great if the staff had a bit more training on trans-specific issues. I know they're doing their best, but sometimes I feel like I'm the one educating them, which isn't really how it should be. The community resources are really helpful with that. I can either look up things other people have posted online, or ask questions if I can't find what I'm looking for. And it would be so much easier if I could combine my PrEP and hormone appointments. That way, I'd have fewer chances of missing one because it's all in one go. Just little things like that would make a big difference.

Gender:

Woman

Age:

23

Location:

Guildford

Interviewer Thank you for joining me today. To start, have you ever looked for sexual health advice or information? If so, what sources did you find, and which (if any) were useful?

Participant Yeah, I've definitely looked for information. I think I started when I was around 18, just trying to get a better understanding of everything. At first, I mostly used the NHS website because it felt the most reliable. I've also used some sexual health apps, like ones where you can ask anonymous questions. Oh, and there's a charity called Brook that I found quite helpful—they have a lot of information targeted at younger people. I'd say the NHS site and Brook were the most useful, but I wish they were a bit more detailed on how to actually have conversations about this stuff. Like, they cover the facts, but not always the social side, if that makes sense.

Interviewer That does make sense. So, are sexual health services something you have engaged with in the past?

Participant Yes, I've been using them pretty regularly since I started uni. I go for testing mostly, but also for advice. I make it a point to get tested every three months, even if I haven't had any new partners, just because I want to stay on top of it. I've also got emergency contraception a couple of times, and I went once to talk about contraception options when I wanted to switch from the pill to the implant.

Interviewer What motivated you to engage with those services?

Participant Honestly, I'm just very anxious about my health, and that extends to sexual health. I've seen friends go through situations where they didn't get checked for ages, and I just don't want to take that risk. It's also about peace of mind—like, if I get tested regularly, then I don't have to worry about it as much. But I wish I didn't feel as anxious about it in the first place.

Interviewer What was it like trying to get an appointment? Can you describe the process?

Participant In Guildford, it's usually not too hard. The clinic lets you book online, which I like because I don't really want to call and talk to someone about it. Sometimes you have to wait a week or so, but if it's urgent, they try to fit you in, but you have to call for urgent things. The online booking is better because it means I can do it in private, which I think is really important—sometimes just the act of booking feels like a barrier, especially if you're feeling embarrassed or worried.

Interviewer And how did it feel accessing those services? Were they comfortable, friendly, clinical?

Participant I'd say a mix of friendly and clinical. Like, they're very professional, but they also make an effort to put you at ease. The staff are always really respectful, and they don't make you feel judged, which is huge because I think a lot of people, including me, feel self-conscious about even going. I guess my anxiety makes me expect it to be awkward, but usually, it's actually fine.

Interviewer Were you ever offered other services at the same time?

Participant Sometimes, yeah. Like if I'm there for testing, they'll ask if I want to talk about contraception options or if I've had my HPV vaccine. I remember that although I'd had the HPV vaccination at school, they offered a newer version which covers more things. They're quite good about

checking in on different aspects of sexual health, which I appreciate. It makes it feel more holistic, like they're looking at everything instead of just treating one issue. Especially for young women, obviously contraception is also really important and they're able to offer those services at the same time.

Interviewer Do you have a regular schedule for engaging with these services, or is it more ad-hoc?

Participant It's pretty regular. Like I said, I try to go every three months for testing. I have a reminder on my phone. I know that might sound a bit intense, but it helps me manage my anxiety about it. I think if I left it more to chance, I'd probably just end up stressing out all the time.

Interviewer Have you ever needed treatment for an STI?

Participant No, thankfully. I've had a couple of scares where I was convinced I had something, but it was always just anxiety. I think that's why I'm so adamant about getting tested regularly—it's like I need that confirmation that everything's okay.

Interviewer I understand. In general, what do you think has been positive about your engagements with sexual health services?

Participant I'd say the biggest thing is how approachable and non-judgmental the staff are. It makes a huge difference. They're really patient, and they explain things clearly without making you feel dumb. Plus, it's nice that there's a range of services in one place, so you can sort of tackle everything at once if you need to. It's also been good for me to see that they take it seriously, because I feel like a lot of people I know don't see sexual health as a priority, and that can be frustrating.

Interviewer And what, if anything, has been negative or left room for improvement?

Participant I guess there's still that underlying stigma that makes it hard for people, including me, to talk about it openly. Even though the staff are great, it's like society hasn't caught up yet. I think it would help if there was more support around how to actually have those conversations with partners—like, not just the physical health side, but the emotional side too. I've read guides online, but it's different from having a real conversation about it. I'd love to see the clinics offer workshops or one-on-one sessions on that kind of thing, just to help build confidence.

Interviewer That's a great point. It sounds like you're very proactive, but there's still a gap in support when it comes to discussing sexual health with partners, or potential partners?

Participant Exactly. I'm doing what I can to take care of myself, but I still get nervous talking to partners about it. I want to be more confident, but it feels like such a delicate subject. Like, I don't want them to think I'm accusing them of something or making things awkward. It's frustrating because I know it shouldn't be such a big deal to talk about it, but it still is.

Interviewer Have you tried to talk about it before? What happened?

Participant I have. And usually we sort of muddle through a short conversation. I'd like to be able to ask more questions and reassure myself, but I feel self-conscious and worried so I usually just ask if they've been tested recently, and they'll say yes. Honestly it's not always very convincing, but I don't know how to make it feel more natural and comfortable, to make that conversation feel more open and honest.

Interviewer Are there any other sexual health aspects you think could be improved? Or anything you've been pleasantly surprised by?

Participant One thing that could be improved is the availability of appointments. Like I said, it's usually okay, but there have been times when I wanted to see someone quickly, and it was hard to get an appointment soon enough. I think it would help if they had more walk-in slots or maybe even extended hours, especially for people who work or have classes during the day. It's not always easy to find a time that fits, and that can make people put it off. But on the positive side, I've been pleasantly surprised by how easy it is to get home testing kits. I didn't even know they were a thing until a couple of years ago, and it's such a relief that I can do it privately at home if I'm really nervous or busy. I think it makes testing feel more accessible and less intimidating, and I've recommended it to a few friends who felt awkward about going to the clinic in person. Also, I was surprised the first time I went to the clinic and they offered a mental health check-in. I wasn't expecting it, but I think it's a great idea. Sexual health is so closely tied to your mental well-being, and it was nice to see them acknowledge that. It was just a quick chat, but it made me feel like they were treating me as a whole person, not just dealing with my test results. So yeah, that was a pleasant surprise.

Interviewer Thank you for sharing that. It sounds like you've really thought a lot about these issues, and it's helpful to hear about your experiences.

Age:

26

Gender:

Woman

Location:

Bath

Interviewer Thank you for agreeing to talk with me today. To start off, have you ever looked for sexual health advice or information? If so, what sources did you find, and which (if any) were useful?

Participant Yeah, I have. I remember when I first started dating women, I was really confused because most of the information out there was about straight couples, so it didn't feel very relevant. I mostly went online and tried to read articles and forums. I also used some websites, like NHS and Terrence Higgins Trust, which were helpful, but I had to do a lot of searching to find advice that was specific to lesbian women. I'd say the NHS site is good for general information, but I found the Terrence Higgins Trust a bit better because it covers different communities more specifically.

Interviewer That makes sense. It sounds like it took a bit of effort to find what you needed. So, are sexual health services something you've engaged with in the past?

Participant Yes, I have. I've gone a few times, mostly for testing and once for treatment. I also thought about going for advice on safe sex, but I never really felt comfortable enough to bring it up in person, you know? I just looked that up online.

Interviewer What kind of services were you looking for when you did engage with them? Was it mostly testing, treatment, or something else?

Participant Mostly testing. I had a bit of a wake-up call a few years ago when a partner reached out to me to let me know she tested positive for chlamydia. I was honestly really shocked because I thought I was low risk—I mean, I wasn't sleeping around a lot, and I always thought STIs were more common among straight people. So I went in to get tested, and that's when I found out I had it, too. Since then, I've tried to get tested more regularly, even though it's still a bit uncomfortable for me to go to the clinic.

Interviewer What was your motivation for going for testing after you were notified by your partner?

Participant Well, I definitely didn't want to have something and not know about it. After that experience, I realized I couldn't assume I was safe just because I wasn't in a high-risk group, or at least what I thought was a high-risk group. Plus, it was important for me to make sure I didn't pass anything on to other partners. I didn't want anyone to be caught off guard like I was.

Interviewer I understand. And how was the process of getting an appointment? Did you find it easy to access the services?

Participant It wasn't too difficult, but it wasn't super easy either. The first time I went, I called the clinic, and I remember being really nervous on the phone. I wasn't sure what to expect, and I didn't know how much I'd have to explain over the phone. Luckily, the receptionist was nice, but it still felt a bit awkward. Now I just book online, which is a lot easier for me. But sometimes the waiting times can be a bit long, especially if you're anxious to get it done.

Interviewer And what did it feel like accessing those services once you were there? Did you find it comfortable, or was it a bit more clinical and impersonal?

Participant Honestly, it felt pretty clinical. I know they're just doing their job, but it felt like they were just trying to get me in and out as quickly as possible. I understand it's a busy place, but I didn't feel super comfortable. I was already a bit anxious about the whole thing, and the atmosphere didn't really help. I also think it's because I don't really see a lot of other people like me there, so I felt a bit out of place.

Interviewer Were you ever offered other services at the same time, like advice or information on different topics?

Participant Not really. I guess they asked if I wanted to get tested for other STIs, but that was about it. There was no conversation about safe sex between women, which I think could have been useful, especially when I first started getting tested. It felt like they assumed I already knew everything I needed to know, which wasn't true.

Interviewer Do you have a regular schedule for engaging with sexual health services, or is it more ad-hoc, depending on the situation?

Participant It's more ad-hoc, to be honest. I get tested maybe once or twice a year, depending on how things are going. After the chlamydia situation, I try to be more consistent, but I still don't have a set routine. I mostly go when I feel like I need to, or if I've had a new partner.

Interviewer You mentioned having needed treatment for chlamydia. Can you tell me a bit about what that process was like for you?

Participant Yeah, sure. So, after I got the test results back, they called me and told me I was positive. I had to go back to the clinic to pick up antibiotics. It wasn't too complicated, but I remember feeling really embarrassed. Even though I knew it wasn't a big deal, I still felt like I'd done something wrong. It felt a bit isolating, especially because I didn't really have anyone to talk to about it who would understand.

Interviewer Did you feel like you had adequate information and advice at each stage of the process, or would you have liked more of anything at any point?

Participant I wish they'd explained more about how common it is, and that it's not something to be ashamed of. The whole thing was over pretty quickly, but there wasn't much time to ask questions. I left with the antibiotics and some printed info, but I felt like I still had a lot of unanswered questions. I ended up doing more research online later, which helped.

Interviewer Did you need to notify anyone about your positive result, and if so, what was that experience like?

Participant Yeah, I had to tell my partner at the time, which was really awkward. I was so scared she'd think I was cheating or being careless. I mean, she was actually very understanding about it, but it was still a really difficult conversation to have. I wish I'd had more guidance on how to approach that, because I felt very alone in figuring out what to say.

Interviewer In general, what do you think has been positive about your engagements with sexual health services?

Participant I'd say the fact that the services are there at all is really positive. Like, I'm glad I can just go and get tested without it being a huge deal. I know it's important to take care of my health, and they make that possible. And when I needed treatment, I was able to get it quickly, which was a relief.

Interviewer And what, if anything, has been negative or left room for improvement?

Participant I think the biggest thing is just feeling uncomfortable or out of place. I don't always feel like the services are for people like me, if that makes sense. It would help if there was more visibility for LGBTQ+ people, or if they made it clear that they're open to discussing issues that affect people in same-sex relationships. And, like I said, I wish they'd taken a bit more time to explain things instead of just giving me a leaflet and sending me on my way. Even just a bit of reassurance would've made a big difference.

Age:

40

Gender:

Man

Location:

Havant

Interviewer Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today. I want to start by asking if you've ever looked for sexual health advice or information. If so, what sources did you find, and which ones were useful?

Participant Yes I have. I'd say I've mostly looked things up online. NHS websites are good, especially because I find it easier when things are written out clearly. I've also used a few apps that have information on sexual health, but I prefer websites because they're usually more reliable. I've gone to the sexual health clinic in Portsmouth a few times too, and I find it easier to just ask them directly if I have questions. They're usually straightforward with their answers, which I appreciate.

Interviewer That makes sense. So, it sounds like you've engaged with sexual health services before. Could you tell me more about what kind of services you were looking for and what motivated you to use them?

Participant I've been to the clinic for a few things. Mostly testing, but I've also gone to ask about vaccinations and to ask questions that the advice did not cover. I've got a few regular partners, and I want to make sure I'm being a responsible person. It's important to me, so if I end up meeting someone new, even if it's rare, I'll usually get tested afterwards.

Interviewer That sounds responsible, and it's great to hear. You mentioned some questions that you couldn't find answers to online, could you give some examples?

Participant There are different types of test for some STIs, and I wanted to know which tests my clinic was using, and how the accuracy varied. The different tests sometimes pick things up at different stages, too, so I needed to find out how soon after meeting someone new I should get tested, based on the tests that my clinic actually used. That information was not on the website, and so it's hard to understand the exact detail of the service. Now, when I get tested in the clinic I check to see whether they are still using the same tests or if they have changed.

Interviewer It sounds like a level of detail is important to you?

Participant Yes, I am details oriented. Detail is important in my job and in my life generally. So being able to find that out helps me to plan my care better. I wish that more detail was given in the test results themselves. The system must know what kind of test was carried out, so why don't they share that with patients?

Interviewer That's a good point. Can you tell me what it was like trying to get an appointment for testing or advice? What was the process like?

Participant Booking an appointment is usually straightforward, but it depends. When I call, I try to make sure I ask exactly what I need to, or I can get a bit lost. They usually have clear options on the phone, which helps. Sometimes, if I walk in without an appointment, I might have to wait a while, but they're quite good at letting me know when I can be seen. I like it better when I can just book online and see exactly when there's a free slot — it makes it easier to plan around work and it must be more efficient for the service too.

Interviewer And how did you feel about accessing the services? Was the environment comfortable for you?

Participant Yes, mostly. The clinic I go to is friendly. It is still a bit clinical, which is to be expected, but the staff are friendly. I feel like I can ask them the questions that I have, and they don't make a big deal out of it. That's good because I don't like it when things are left vague or if they talk around the subject — it's easier when people say what they mean.

Interviewer Were you ever offered any other services at the same time, like additional tests or advice?

Participant Sometimes, yes. If I'm there for testing, they'll ask if I need advice on anything else or if I want to get vaccinated. Once, they talked to me about the HPV vaccine, which was useful because I did not know that it was available to men and can potentially protect your partners from cervical cancer.

Interviewer Do you have a regular schedule for getting tested, or is it more on an as-needed basis?

Participant It's mostly on an as-needed basis. I get tested every three months, but if I have a new partner, I'll make sure to go in sooner. I am very consistent, and I use my diary to remind when a test is due, and also when I need to try and book in order that an appointment will be available at the time I need it. My system is not perfect. Sometimes I cannot get an appointment in the week that I would like, because they have none left, or because they are late to release the slots.

Interviewer Got it. Have you ever needed treatment for an STI? If so, could you tell me what that process was like?

Participant Yes, I have had chlamydia twice, and once gonorrhoea. It was a bit of a surprise and quite stressful to be told. I got the result from the clinic, and they called me to come in. They explained everything well, which was good because I wasn't sure what to expect. In both cases they gave me antibiotics and went over how I needed to take them, and what to watch out for. gonorrhoea requires an injection in the buttock, which I would not like to repeat. It was all handled quickly, but I didn't like having to tell my partners. That was the hardest part.

Interviewer I understand. How did it go when you had to notify your partners?

Participant Not very well. I was honest, and they took it okay, but I could tell they were uncomfortable. It's not easy bringing that up. I think there's a lot of stigma around it, even though I was trying to do the right thing. I'd rather just handle it myself and keep it private, but I know that's not the responsible thing to do, so I told them. I wish there were an easier way to approach that. I am quite direct and to the point, but I think other people like things less direct. I find conversations like that difficult to have. I think my partners might have liked more reassurance, but I prefer to just convey the facts.

Interviewer That makes sense, and I appreciate you sharing that. In general, what do you think has been positive about your experiences with sexual health services?

Participant The staff, mainly. They're very clear, and they don't make me feel judged. I think it helps that they're straight to the point and don't talk down to me. I've had other experiences with doctors where they're quite indirect, and it makes me more anxious because I do not always understand what they really want to say. The clinic staff are different — they explain things in a way that makes sense to me.

Interviewer And is there anything that has been negative or left room for improvement?

Participant I think the hardest part is still the stigma. Not so much from the clinic itself, but just around sexual health in general. It's not easy to talk about these things, even though they're important. Sometimes I feel like there could be better support for those conversations, especially when it comes to partners. It's one thing to get the treatment, but then having to tell someone... it's hard, and I don't always know what to say. Maybe they could have a better way of helping with that. I would like a leaflet about how to have a conversation about sexual health with a new partner, to check we both understand and are responsible.

Interviewer That's a really good point, and I'm sure you're not the only one who feels that way. Thanks again for your openness and for sharing your experiences. This has been really helpful.

Age:

52

Gender:

Woman

Location:

Bristol

Interviewer Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today. To start off, I'd like to ask if you've ever looked for sexual health advice or information. If so, what sources did you find, and which (if any) were useful?

Participant Yes, I have. When I first started looking into sexual health services about eight years ago, I was coming out of a long-term relationship, and suddenly I needed to think about these things again. I did a lot of searching online—mainly on NHS websites, some health blogs, and even a few forums. The NHS information was helpful but quite basic and very factual, and I noticed it was mostly geared towards younger people. I felt like there wasn't a lot there for someone my age. That's what led me to start exploring private clinics where I could get more personalized advice, which ended up being really beneficial.

Interviewer That's interesting. Could you tell me a bit more about your engagement with sexual health services? What sort of services were you looking for, and what motivated you to seek them out?

Participant At first, it was mainly about regular testing. After my breakup, I started dating again, and I wanted to make sure I was being responsible. I went for screenings just to have peace of mind. Over time, I added more services. I got vaccinated for HPV, and a couple of years ago, when I started going through menopause, I realized I needed more than just testing. That's when I decided to switch to a private clinic, which could offer advice on hormone therapy, sexual health, and even other types of routine screenings. It felt more holistic, which was important to me at that stage.

Interviewer I see. And what was the process like when you were trying to get an appointment? Was it easy, or did you face any challenges?

Participant It was a bit of a mix. With the NHS clinic, it was quite a process. You'd have to call up, and often there'd be a bit of a wait to get through, then try to find a slot that matched my schedule, which was tricky because I travel for work. It could be a bit stressful. I did try the postal testing kits once, but I just didn't feel comfortable with that. It seemed too impersonal, and I prefer talking to someone face-to-face. Switching to the private clinic made a big difference. They're much more flexible with scheduling, and the atmosphere is so much nicer. Instead of sitting in a clinical waiting room, you're in a cozy space with comfortable chairs and a few tasteful magazines. It feels less like a medical appointment and more like a service that's actually catering to you.

Interviewer You mentioned feeling more comfortable at the private clinic, how did accessing services at the NHS clinic feel in comparison?

Participant The NHS clinic wasn't bad, but it felt quite sterile and, to be honest, a bit rushed. It was mostly younger people there, and I sometimes felt a bit out of place. It was clear they were doing their best with the resources they had, but I didn't always feel like there was enough time to ask all my questions or have a proper conversation. At the private clinic, the staff take their time to make sure you're comfortable and informed, and I really appreciate that. It makes it easier to bring up concerns or ask for advice.

Interviewer You mentioned the private clinic also offers other services. Were you offered additional services when you visited, or was it mostly focused on what you came for?

Participant Yes, they definitely offer more than just what I initially went in for. When I started seeing them for menopause-related advice, they made sure I knew I could continue with regular sexual health screenings. They also do cervical screenings, breast cancer checks, and even general wellness consultations. It's nice not having to run around to different places for these things. I can just book a single appointment and take care of everything I need. Given my schedule, that's been really convenient.

Interviewer Do you have a regular schedule for engaging with these services, or is it more on an ad-hoc basis?

Participant It's quite regular now. I try to do my sexual health screenings twice a year, and I have check-ups for the menopause treatment every few months. I find that it helps to keep a routine because then I'm not scrambling to make appointments last minute, especially if work gets busy. I would be interested in video consultations, particularly for follow-ups, but they haven't offered that yet. Hopefully, they'll consider it in the future.

Interviewer Understood. I'd like to ask if you've ever needed treatment for an STI. If so, what was that experience like?

Participant Thankfully, no, I haven't needed treatment for an STI. But I still make sure to get tested regularly. I think it's important, especially as my thoughts on condom use have changed a bit since I went through menopause. I don't have to worry about pregnancy anymore, so I'm not as strict about it as I used to be. I still use them quite often, but I know I might be taking a bit more risk than I did in the past. It's an interesting shift, and it's something I've talked about with my provider just to make sure I'm staying safe.

Interviewer That's a really important point. In general, what would you say has been positive about your experiences with sexual health services?

Participant At the private clinic, the best part is definitely the environment and the way they handle appointments. The staff are friendly, and they make you feel welcome, not like you're just another patient to get through. They're also good at explaining things and making sure you're informed, which I didn't always feel at the NHS clinic. Having everything in one place, hormone therapy, screenings, or just advice, makes things simpler and less stressful.

Interviewer And is there anything you think could be improved, or anything you've found negative about your engagements with these services?

Participant I'd say the main issue with the NHS clinic was the scheduling. It was always tricky to get appointments that worked around my work commitments, and I often felt like I had to rush in and out. There was this sense that the clinic was more geared towards younger people, wasn't much there that felt aimed at someone in their 50s who might be dealing with different concerns. Moving from the NHS to private care also had its own challenges. One thing that really stood out was having to go through a full sexual history again when I switched to the private clinic. It was quite time-consuming after more than 30 years of being sexually active, it's hard to remember all the details! I didn't even know what specific vaccinations I'd had and when. It felt a bit overwhelming to try to dig up that information, and it made me wonder why it wasn't easier to access and share between providers. You'd think there would be a system in place for that by now. Even at the private clinic, there's still room for improvement. I'd really like to see them offer video consultations, especially for follow-ups. It would be a huge help for people who travel frequently, like I do, or who just need a quick check-in without making a trip. I hope they'll consider adding that soon.

Interviewer Thank you for sharing all of that. It's been really insightful to hear about your experiences. Is there anything else you'd like to add before we finish?

Participant Just that I hope there's more recognition that sexual health is important for everyone, not just younger people. As we get older, our needs change, but that doesn't mean we stop needing these services. It's been interesting to see how my own views have shifted over the years, and I'm glad I've had access to good care.

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